



Iraq



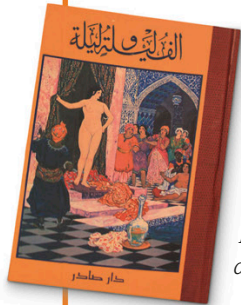
The land of rivers

The Euphrates and Tigris rivers, and their branches, form a large river system. These waterways irrigate the land, enriching the soil and making it easy to grow crops.



Life on the water

The Marsh Arabs of the southeastern wetlands of Iraq use local reeds to make their houses and boats. This community has lived in the Iraqi marshes for 5,000 years.



One Thousand and One Nights

This is a classic collection of Arab and Persian folk tales. Many of its stories are set in Baghdad.



0 150 km
0 150 miles
(approximate scale)

Ancient entrance

The Ishtar Gate, built in 575 BCE, was one of the entrances to the Mesopotamian city of Babylon. This smaller replica stands in the ancient city's ruins, just east of Karbala.

The minaret spirals 171 ft (52 m) like a snail's shell.



Religious relics

The ancient Mesopotamians were skilled artisans, making jewelry and statues, such as this figurine of a worshipper from about 2500 BCE.

Great Mosque of Samarra

A stone minaret is all that remains of what was once the largest mosque in the world, built in the 9th century CE in the city of Samarra.



The **modern nation of Iraq** in southwestern Asia lies in a region that was once called **Mesopotamia**. Here, the **world's first civilizations** blossomed in the **fertile valleys** of the **Tigris and Euphrates rivers**, developing agriculture and writing. Today, Iraq is known for its **large reserves of oil**, which it exports to many countries.



- 169,235 sq miles (438,317 sq km)
- 38.9 million
- Baghdad
- Arabic, other languages (4+)